



Oslo Opera House

Location Oslo, Norway

Oslo Opera House, designed by architectural firm Snøhetta, was built in 2003–2007. Its waterfront setting and contrasting planes and angles inevitably suggest a kind of Nordic iceberg—a point reinforced by the expanse of marble that slopes down, around, and across it. The vast plaza is truly a public space that actively encourages visitors to explore. Even the roof is accessible. It also acts as a dramatic setting for the glass-fronted lobby that rises from and across it like a gigantic dormer window. The detailing is exceptional. The looming bulk of the stage-tower is clad in burnished aluminum. The no less high-tech auditorium, under a vast oval chandelier, is faced with darkly stained oak.

National Museum of 21st Century Arts

Location Rome, Italy

The National Museum of 21st Century Arts—*Museo nazionale delle arti del XXI secolo* in Italian, MAXXI for short—was the work of the prolific Iraqi-born British architect Zaha Hadid. It was built

in 1998–2010. Hadid conceived of the building as a river delta, its channels dividing and multiplying. Despite the massiveness of much of the concrete building—itself a reference to the ancient Roman use of concrete—it ebbs and flows in ways that always surprise. Corridors suddenly curve or straighten, resembling a surreal highway intersection. Materials take on a sort of dissolving, translucent quality. Running through much of the building are underlit black staircases.

Rolex Learning Center

Location Lausanne, Switzerland

The Rolex Learning Center, which opened in 2010, is part of the École Polytechnique Fédérale de Lausanne, or EPFL. Containing a library, teaching centers, and various public amenities, it was designed by Japanese architects Kazuyo Sejima and Ryue Nishizawa. Seen from above, it appears modest: a simple concrete rectangle of 400,000 square ft (37,000 square m), pierced by a series of round and oval openings. However, seen from

▼ THE UNDULATING STRUCTURE OF THE ROLEX LEARNING CENTER

the side, it reveals itself as a kind of magic carpet, in a permanent state of elegant, unforced flux. It is scarcely imposing—nowhere is it more than 30 ft (9 m) high—and its walls are made entirely of glass. Inside and out, it rises and falls in gentle rhythms, as if breathing.

The Shard

Location London, England

No building as vast as Italian architect Renzo Piano's Shard—officially known as the London Bridge Tower—can fail to generate controversy. Constructed between 2009 and 2012, its 95 stories soar 1,020 ft (310 m) over London. Perhaps ironically, its universally used name was originally intended to denigrate it. The English Heritage Trust called the proposed building a “shard of glass through the heart of London.” There is no doubting its audacity. An irregularly shaped, attenuated pyramid ends in eight separate razorlike points. Differences in the angling of the 11,000 panes of glass cause the building to change its glinting appearance as the light and seasons change. At night, lit from within, it appears otherworldly. Loved or loathed, it has transformed London's skyline.

the temperature goes above 68°F (20°C). Above all, it represents a vision of architecture that suggests unlimited possibilities.

